

Ageing YOUNG

Diabetes and heart disease may be the biggest killers in the country, but the early onset of arthritis poses a bigger risk to the young, thanks to their unhealthy and sedentary lifestyles

By Nishika Patel

It's no secret that the young are buckling under the pressure of fast-paced, city life but it is a bit of a revelation that their knees and hips are giving in too. Arthritis is crippling the young who are now finding themselves growing old before their time. Like software developer Ketan Mhatre who is only 33 but could easily have been mistaken for a 60-year-old from the way he shuffled up the stairs before hip and knee surgery. He hobbled on crutches as his knees were bent 60 degrees. It should have been the prime of his professional and social life, but he was homebound for two years. He blames stressful, irregular work patterns for the onset of rheumatoid arthritis and his condition.

Osteoarthritis should be the biggest worry for the young and restless in India. It's a degenerative disease which results in wearing and tearing of the joints. It has emerged as the No. 1 disease among those aged between 25 and 35, according to a health study carried out by Delhi-based market research agency TNS.

VARSHA PANDHRE, 36

Patient Of: Rheumatoid Arthritis

Treatment: Hip resurfacing and knee joint replacement

Pandhre started getting joint pains 10 years ago after the birth of her first child who was born premature at seven months. Her daughter, who weighed only 1.4 kg, was in the ICU for one month. For one year Pandhre went through

physical and mental stress and it took its toll on her. The arthritis became acute and she could not walk without support. "I used to walk like an old woman. I was embarrassed because people used to stare at me," she says. She missed playing with her daughters Shweta, 12, and Dollie, 6. After a joint knee replacement in her right knee in May 2009, she is on the road to recovery with the help of her parents and husband.

MANDAR DEODHAR/www.indiatodayimages.com

